

Hunters and Gatherers

Hunting and foraging for food was the only way of life for all humans up until 12,000 years ago. It was a successful lifestyle that, in some ways, had significant advantages over a life of farming. Today, only a handful of hunter-gatherer societies survive, in the Amazon Basin and Africa.

We have been able to understand more about the hunter-gatherer diet from surviving artifacts such as carved stone and bone tools and decorative items (see pp.34–35), and also from hunting scenes in rock paintings, such as those at Lascaux,

France, and Altamira, Spain. Rare finds of wooden digging sticks and flint sickle blades show that people dug for tubers and harvested wild grasses. Broken animal and fish bones, and fossil plant pollens, reveal details of the hunter-gatherer diet, as do deep shell middens (waste sites) crammed with the discarded shells of edible mollusks.

In addition, the few surviving hunter-gatherer societies can tell us first-hand about the dynamics of human existence before agriculture and animal domestication.

Mammoth hunters

Most hunter-gatherer bands were constantly on the move, camping near lakes and other strategic locations during the times of year when a particular plant food ripened or game was close by. At Dolní Vestonice, in what is now the Czech Republic, mammoth hunters lived in oval bone-and-timber huts (see p.26)

The hunter's equipment

The earliest weapons took the form of simple flint arrowheads. As hunters became more sophisticated, weapons grew more specialized. The harpoon point, below, is carved from bone and suited to fishing. Arrows would have been used about 8,000 years ago for hunting.

overlooking a river valley and nearby swamps. Among the objects found at the site, which dates back to the last Ice Age, is the oldest known ceramic in the world—a “Venus” figurine (a carving

shaped like a female figure) dating to between 29,000 and 25,000 BCE. Other carvings of bears, lions, and mammoths indicate a culture of some degree of sophistication. A similar date has been given to the Venus of Willendorf (see p.34) found in Austria. It has been suggested that these figurines represent fertility and the success of the hunter-gatherer group they are associated with.

Stone age transition

The line between nomadic hunting and gathering and settled farming is not always clear. Many communities may have stayed in one place while hunting, or moved around and cultivated crops. Ten thousand years ago, bands of Mesolithic (Middle Stone Age) fishers and hunters lived by the Baltic Sea, which at that stage was newly uncovered by retreating ice. Their diet mainly consisted of fish, supplemented by birds, plant foods, and game, caught

BEFORE

Hunting and gathering, or foraging for food, is the fundamental way that humans and their ancestors lived. The success of the species depended on their ability to use Earth's resources to their own advantage.

HUMAN SCAVENGERS

Evidence from bones and flints has shown that early humans may have eaten the remains of animals killed by other predators rather than hunting for most of their food.

A VARIED DIET

As the first modern humans spread around the world << 24–29 their diet changed in response to **locally available foods**. A process of trial and error would have been necessary while learning what foods were good to eat and what could potentially be harmful.

CHANGING TO SURVIVE

Human societies throughout the world had to **adapt to radically different environments**. Predictability, seasonality, abundance, and **distribution of food resources** such as fish and nuts affected their choice to live a nomadic or more settled existence.

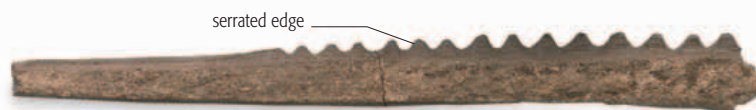


HAZELNUTS



Gathered food

Wild plant foods, whether grasses, nuts, or tubers, were the dominant staple for most ancient hunter-gatherer societies. In most societies, women did the gathering.



HARPOON POINT



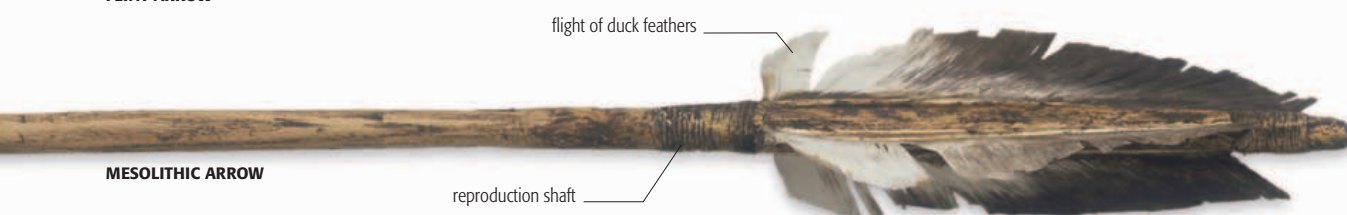
FISHING SPEAR

twine binding



FLINT ARROW

flints stuck in groove of wooden shaft



MESOLITHIC ARROW

flight of duck feathers

reproduction shaft



using stone-tipped arrows, antler harpoons, and wooden spears. Many groups in this area occupied the same settlements for generations, living along shorelines that shifted constantly.

Another site that has revealed details about a community that was hunting and gathering while on the move throughout the year is Star Carr in northeastern England. In 9000 BCE, a small group of Mesolithic people settled on waterlogged ground by a lake there. The wet conditions preserved flint tools, the remains of the elk and red deer they hunted, and the barbed spear points they used to kill them. Teeth and seeds tell us the site was occupied every year from March to June. These people adapted successfully to a rapidly changing post-Ice Age world by